

Total is not determined by a single instance or Total will be determined by a small number of extreme events observation

When you observe for a while you can get to know It takes a long time to know what's going on what's going on

Tyranny of the collective

Tyranny of the accidental

Easy to predict from what you see and extend to what you do not see

Hard to predict from past information

History crawls

History makes jumps

Events are distributed^{*} according to the “bell curve” (the GIF) or its variations

The distribution is either Mandelbrotian “gray” Swans (tractable scientifically) or totally intractable Black Swans

^{*} What I call “probability distribution” here is the model used to calculate the odds of different events, how they are distributed. When I say that an event is distributed according to the “bell curve,” I mean that the Gaussian bell curve (after C. F. Gauss; more on him later) can help provide probabilities of various occurrences.

This framework, showing that Extremistan is where most of the Black Swan action is, is only a rough approximation—please do not Platonify it; don’t simplify it beyond what’s necessary.

Extremistan does not always imply Black Swans. Some events can be rare and consequential, but somewhat predictable, particularly to those who are prepared for them and have the tools to understand them (instead of listening to statisticians, economists, and charlatans of the bell-curve variety). They are near-Black Swans. They are somewhat tractable scientifically—knowing about their incidence should lower your surprise; these events are rare but expected. I call this special case of “gray” swans Mandelbrotian randomness. This category encompasses the randomness that produces phenomena commonly known by terms such as *scalable*, *scale-invariant*, *power laws*, *Pareto-Zipf laws*, *Yule’s law*, *Paretian-stable processes*, *Levy-stable*, and *fractal laws*, and we will leave them aside for now since they will be covered in some depth in Part Three. They are scalable, according to the logic of this chapter, but you can know a little more about *how* they scale since they share much with the laws of nature.

You can still experience severe Black Swans in Mediocristan, though not easily. How? You may forget that something is random, think that it is deterministic, then have a surprise. Or you can tunnel and miss on a source of uncertainty, whether mild or wild, owing to lack of imagination—most Black Swans result from this “tunneling” disease, which I will discuss in [Chapter 9](#).^{*}

This has been a “literary” overview of the central distinction of this book, offering a trick to distinguish between what can belong in Mediocristan and what belongs in Extremistan. I said that I will get into a more thorough examination in Part Three, so let us focus on epistemology for now and see how the distinction affects our knowledge.

^{*} To those readers who Googled Yevgenia Krasnova, I am sorry to say that she is (officially) a fictional character.